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Family Corruption: Relatives in Corrupt Transactions

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ABSTRACT

Although corruption is commonly portrayed as a socially harmful and unethical behavior, and family is often regarded as the building block of society, this article argues that the two often intersect in real life. Kinship ties frequently serve not only as sources of emotional support but also as conduits for illicit transactions and for resource misallocation. From minor nepotism to large-scale state capture, family relationships frequently shape how corruption is organized, justified, and sustained. Drawing on interdisciplinary theories, this article develops a five-part typology of family corruption—family for corruption, corruption for family, corruption for survival through family, corruption for the family firm, and dynastic state capture. Each reflects different positions, motivations, and coordination mechanisms, ranging from micro-level kin-based trust to a macro-level neopatrimonial system. Challenging the idealized separation of family from formal institutions, the article shows how familial obligations can override universalistic norms, embedding corruption within the everyday practices and moral orders. The article contributes a new conceptual framework for understanding how formal systems of government and business are shaped by kinship logics—often beneath the surface of legality and bureaucracy.

1 | Introduction

Family is often viewed as the foundational unit of society—a source of identity, loyalty, and social cohesion—while corruption is typically portrayed as a pathological deviation from normative social and institutional conduct. Across diverse cultures, family bonds are regarded as paramount, whereas corruption is condemned as morally corrosive. However, the intersection of these two social arrangements is more common than most of us think. Realities challenge the presumed mutual exclusivity between family and corruption, as they often go hand in hand.

Indeed, opportunities for corruption involving family members arise daily in various social situations. A striking example is the widespread presence of family-owned businesses, which make up most of the companies worldwide, often blending informal family norms and interests with impersonal business rationality (European Commission 2008; Song et al. 2021). Political elites—whether in authoritarian regimes or liberal democracies—routinely appoint family members to influential roles or back their electoral ambitions (Loxton 2024). Similarly, private sector executives can misuse their authority to help kin secure jobs or promotions, often regardless of their merit. Public officials may have the discretion to channel state contracts to firms owned by relatives. A mayor might misuse public resources for the private benefit of their family, such as refurbishing a relative's home using city labor and materials. Family members may also function as brokers in illicit arrangements, facilitating introductions and transactions between corrupt partners.

These examples, while varied, reveal recurring patterns that demand closer examination. Why does the family become involved in corrupt practices? What roles do relatives play in successfully facilitating a corrupt transaction? Can corruption--paradoxically--reinforce family solidarity and cohesion? This article attempts to answer these questions. I focus on a particular social setup in which family and corruption interplay: situations where family membership is an essential element of a

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corrupt transaction. I refer to these configurations as *family corruption*.

Family corruption does not happen by chance. This unique arrangement exists—embedded in the complex layers of social life, in fact—because it serves to provide specific and concrete benefits to the participants. The scale of this phenomenon ranges from fairly low-level nepotism —such as using one's influence and connections to secure a relative a job—to grand corruption schemes, where powerful families take over the state's redistributive processes and channel significant resources to family members through complex organizational and contractual structures. Family corruption takes various forms; sometimes family members are involved on the bribe-taker agent's side, while at other times they act as a client who gives bribes. In certain instances, family members participate on both sides of the corrupt exchange.

Although this dimension of corruption is less recognized, situations involving family members and opportunities for corruption are more common than we usually realize. This article is primarily a conceptual effort to develop and refine a theoretical framework for the understudied topic of family corruption. It draws on theories from sociology, political science, anthropology, economics, and organization studies to explore and understand the various forms of family corruption. The study offers both theoretical and practical contributions by developing a framework that lies between the utilitarian and constructivist approaches to corruption. Despite its ubiquity across cultures and historical eras, the entanglement of family ties with corrupt practices remains largely undertheorized. This article deepens our understanding of this phenomenon by introducing a novel conceptual framework for analyzing how family relations and corruption shape one another, treating such practices not merely as personal greed or moral deviation but as patterned, socially embedded processes. By moving beyond traditional dichotomies such as public versus private and modern versus premodern, the article offers a more nuanced perspective that reveals how kinship networks systematically influence corrupt transactions and vice versa, emphasizing the complexity of such relationships. In doing so, it highlights that family corruption—far from being an anecdotal or archaic anomaly—follows recognizable logics and can even serve socially functional roles, such as enhancing family cohesion or compensating for dysfunctions across government and market systems. Conceptually, this perspective is critical because it challenges the assumption that corruption operates outside of core social institutions, demonstrating instead how family ties, norms, and loyalties often intertwine with formal systems in consequential ways. Practically, understanding corruption through this family lens helps create more tailored policies to combat this particular type of illicit activity.

2 | Family, Corruption, and Family Corruption

2.1 | Family

A family is defined as a group of people bound by kinship ties (Ball 1972). Members of this group can be related in various ways: by blood (consanguine), marriage (affinal), or through other legal or informal ceremonies (pseudo or quasi kin). Adoptive parents, godparents, step-relatives, and spiritual kin are the most common examples of this latter category. Some family ties are purposefully created, while others are inherent to the members. Family is a core component of social structure, consisting of groups of statuses and roles that greatly influence human behavior (Martin 2009, 5). It links individuals to larger social collectivities at the micro level by going beyond personal identity. Being part of a family and working for it is frequently seen by people as the true purpose of life (Campbell 1964, 37).

Immediate family typically includes two parents and their children, all of whom usually live together in the same household. The extended family encompasses relatives beyond the nuclear unit, including grandparents, aunts, uncles, and cousins, who often reside in the same household or maintain close ties. Subsequent collectives, such as kinship, lineage, or clan, go beyond the confines of extended family, but most of these large traditional configurations have become obsolete in post-industrial urban environments.

While some form of family structure exists everywhere, families vary greatly across different regions and cultures. They also change over time. Major historical forces like industrialization, post-industrialization, urbanization, and rationalization, the process by which contemporary societies increasingly rely on calculated, rule-based, and efficient means of organization, have significantly reshaped family structures and their roles (Inglehart and Welzel 2005). Kin ties are increasingly elective and must be cultivated to be maintained, and conversely, they can also be easier to cut than in the past (Furstenberg and Cherlin 1991). Although family is becoming a more fluid variable encompassing a wide range of personal associations and identities, living arrangements, and gender roles, blood relations continue to hold significant legal, social, and symbolic relevance in the definition of family (Chambers and Gracia 2022, 1–3; Taylor 2005).

Family is a highly complex social phenomenon with multiple dimensions and related functions and activities. While not all families reproduce biologically (i.e., adoptive families or childless couples) and not all reproduction happens within a family setting, the traditional nuclear family is the prime social unit through which reproduction occurs. The family has long been acknowledged as the primary entity in intimate relationships within society, serving as the foundational framework through which individuals engage in emotional closeness, support, and trust. Yet it also serves as a site for economic transactions involving the consumption, production, and distribution of goods and services. This duality often gives rise to controversy because of the perceived opposition between rationally calculated economic activity and intimate and personal social relations (Zelizer 2005, 13). There is a widespread belief that money, markets, and competition are incompatible with love, care, and moral values. Another key aspect of families is that they are networked structures through which social and economic resources are transferred, and such reciprocal exchanges have also been seen as a crucial mechanism for social integration and solidarity (Adloff and Mau 2006; Girvan and Newman 2002; Viry and Herz 2025). Families do not always act as

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cohesive units with common goals and agendas. Disputes, conflicts, and even physical violence are also natural parts of kin relationships (Dobash et al. 1992; Ralph et al. 2025). While marriage is structured to unite two distinct kinship groups, underlying tensions often persist or intensify between them.

Family is the smallest micro-level unit of society's normative systems. It facilitates societal-level norms and also creates its own unique set of local particularistic norms, effectively guiding how its members are supposed to behave. Families, similarly, can be viewed as fundamental power structures shaped by these informal rules. Several structuring factors within families, including birth order, sibling dynamics, and cousin group size, contribute to establishing hierarchies and power imbalances (Barclay and Conley 2024). The family unit is also inherently gendered, often reflecting a structure rooted in—usually the eldest—male authority that is prevalent still in many contemporary societies (Kibria 1990; Litwak 1960; Soman 2009).

Although we typically view the family as a primary social unit of informality, state regulations have historically penetrated the originally private realm of the family (Collins 2011). Many aspects of family life are legally governed, and family-related events such as birth, death, marriage, divorce, and inheritance are recorded and managed through official records. There is even a specific branch of doctrine called family law that differentiates among people based on their family status, which adds further nuance to the reality behind the perceived divide between family and public life.

2.2 | Corruption

This article argues that family corruption is a distinct form of corruption because of its strong social aspect. This runs counter to the predominant approach, especially in economics and political science, that tends to see corruption as disembedded from society (Garrido et al. 2024). This utilitarian perspective treats corrupt acts as simple exchanges—an agent illegally selling their official decision-making capacity to an outsider is seen as merely a quid pro quo between two self-interested strangers (Banfield 1975; Rose-Ackerman 1975; Shleifer and Vishny 1993). They are motivated primarily by benefit maximization or even by greed. According to these theories, corruption is the same thing all around the world. It is ethically wrong and profoundly harmful because it makes state institutions dysfunctional, wastes tax money, deteriorates service quality, erodes trust in the public sector, reduces investment by increasing uncertainty, raises the cost of doing business, and retards economic growth. The anti-corruption industry and related scholarship, which have emerged by embracing the utilitarian approach, strongly moralizes corruption as a fundamental evil (Garrido et al. 2024). The utilitarian perspective often relies on principal-agent theory to explain corruption by examining the challenges that occur when the principal (e.g., citizens, company executives, the state) delegates work to an agent (e.g., a public official) whose self-interests do not align with those of the principal (Banfield 1975). Due to the agent's discretion and specialized knowledge (information asymmetry between the principal and the agent) and the organization's weak monitoring and accountability systems, the agent can mislead the principal and secretly accept a client's bribes for personal gain.

In contrast to the contextless utilitarian perspective, the constructivist approach—primarily advocated by anthropologists—views corruption as a socially and culturally constructed phenomenon. This framework emphasizes that understanding corruption requires considering local community perspectives instead of relying solely on established and "objective" scientific paradigms (Torsello and Venard 2016). Such research frequently emphasizes the discourse about corruption, positing that its meanings and definitions are contingent upon cultural and historical contexts (de Sardan 1999; Gupta 2012; Parry 2000; Smith 2007). Practices deemed corrupt in one region may be perceived as acceptable or even as moral imperatives in other cultural settings (Hasty 2005). This view holds that corruption is not a universal phenomenon observable in every culture, which also implies that corruption is not inherently negative; it may serve as a survival tool for marginalized groups (Shore and Haller 2005).

I argue that the utilitarian approach fails to address the multifaceted social dynamics associated with corruption, whereas the constructivist approach tends to relativize the phenomenon overly. When corruption is viewed as totally context-dependent, and all definitions are portrayed as equally valid, it potentially excuses harmful practices as mere cultural differences and obscures real power abuses and injustices. My sociological position is between these two approaches. I view corruption as a socially complex phenomenon embedded in micro-level relationships, bureaucratic hierarchies, and broader social structures, but always with room for human agency. While influenced by societal factors, individuals can make choices about corruption. And one of these factors is family, the primary focus of this article.

Although participants may see their actions as non-corrupt or morally acceptable within their cultural context, the transfer of resources among them is real and can be observed empirically, allowing us to study the dynamics of these exchanges. Therefore, the concept of family corruption in this article offers a sociological middle ground: it reveals how actors engage in illicit resource transfers while navigating between the conflicting normative orders and rationalized bureaucratic environments. Here, corruption is neither solely a self-interested act nor entirely a culturally determined practice, but a morally ambiguous one rooted in knotty family relations. Besides its resource-transfer nature, corruption also manifests as an organizational phenomenon. This is primarily because the corruptly transferred resources typically originate from a formal organization, either a business or a government entity, in which at least one corrupt actor is a member (Graycar and Jancsics 2017). Despite the phenomenon's multifaceted nature, general patterns of corrupt exchange within family contexts can be identified across cultures. This article focuses on conceptualizing these patterns.

2.3 | Family Corruption

Family corruption is a relatively understudied and under-theorized concept, but it is worth exploring further and

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establishing it as a distinct analytical category. The primary explanations of the phenomenon suggest that family corruption occurs when the boundaries between private and public spheres are blurred (Fukuyama 2018; De Sousa 2008; Smith 2001). The idea behind this approach is that public and personal spheres in contemporary societies should be clearly distinguished because they operate according to fundamentally opposing principles (Parsons 1978, 15; Zelizer 2005, 43). Family compromises the impartiality and fairness necessary for high-quality governance (Rothstein and Teorell 2015). Therefore, it has no role in the operations of government or private firms.

Most studies on family corruption can be linked to an abstract dichotomy identified by foundational scholars that focuses on the distinction between modern and pre-modern societies (Giordano 2018). They suggest that the family as an organizing principle has roots in pre-modern times, and its presence in contemporary impersonal bureaucracies is not normal, inevitably resulting in corruption. Suppose people are treated according to their family morals instead of receiving a standard treatment that applies to everyone, regardless of the family to which they belong. In that case, the rule of law would not exist (Pippidi, 2007). Several prominent sociologists have emphasized that this is the distinction between modern and pre-modern societies, which is likely best demonstrated by the expectation of equality in the eyes of the law. Although the concepts formulated by these scholars differ slightly, notable similarities can be identified among them (Jenks 1998).

Ferdinand Tönnies's (1912) differentiation between Gemeinschaft (community) and Gesellschaft (society) elucidates two fundamentally contrasting forms of social organization: close-knit, intimate relationships typically observed in traditional contexts such as families or rural communities, and more impersonal, formal, and goal-oriented relationships prevalent in modern, urban, and industrial societies.

Durkheim (1893) presented another similar foundational sociological distinction between mechanical and organic solidarity. Mechanical solidarity emerges in environments of close proximity, where individuals form strong, personalized relationships within relatively small communities featuring minimal division of labor, while organic solidarity arises in industrial societies distinguished by significant social differentiation, resulting in a complex system of labor division that leads to a variety of social roles and a high degree of specialization.

The most influential dichotomy was developed by Weber (1922), who distinguished between patrimonial and modern bureaucratic organizations. This patrimonial organization is characterized by a lack of formal rules, wherein administrative roles are filled based on kinship, loyalty, or favoritism rather than merit or competence. Weber contrasted the patrimonial system with the ideal type of rational-legal bureaucracy, usually defined as involving a written set of regulations, nonhereditary positions, a clear chain of command, and impersonal rules.

Parsons (1951) identified modernity as a significant shift in societal values, especially highlighting the transition from particularism, that is, clans or tribes being left to their own devices, to universalism. Parsons asserted that industrial societies move from particularistic to universalistic values as an essential adaptation to the complexities of the social system.

My article argues that although the modern versus premodern or universalism versus particularism dichotomy has some merit, it is an ideal type that cannot fully capture the complexity and nuance of corrupt cases involving family members. The simplified and abstract binary model suggests that when family stays in its own territory, the private sphere, it has a positive role; it functions as the essential fabric, the building block of society. However, when it enters the public sphere and formal organizations, it undermines the rule of law and is essentially equivalent to corruption. I believe relying on such a strict polarity as a primary explanation for family corruption limits our understanding of the phenomenon. Real-life situations are highly dynamic and embedded in multiple layers of social structure. The private and public spheres are intertwined in many ways and form a continuum rather than a strict binary.

As mentioned earlier, family is a crucial site for economic transactions—activities that many scholars overlook or simplify because they do not fit into the realm of "pure" market transactions studied by economists. Furthermore, the tendency of scholars to completely isolate the concept of family from formal organizations such as government and business entities due to the family's reliance on informal rules, emotional connections, and non-market objectives—seen as inherently incompatible with formal organizations' contractual and impersonal framework—is unfeasible. The reality that approximately two-thirds of companies globally are family-operated challenges the very notion of such a rigid separation (European Commission 2008; Song et al. 2021). The public and private spheres often overlap even in contemporary societies, but this intersection is not necessarily corrupt. Family corruption occurs because it is functional and offers specific illicit benefits to those involved.

3 | Conceptual Framework of Family Corruption

This article is fundamentally a conceptual endeavor, aiming to develop and refine a theoretical framework for an understudied topic, family corruption. Both family and corruption can be examined as distinct forms of social organization. Family–-the oldest organized unit of human cooperation–-is the elementary form of a domestic, multi-purpose corporate entity. It is present in all human societies, with some common functions (Ahrne 1990, 57–58; Oberg 1938; Wolf 1956; Yanagisako 1979). Similarly with corruption, given the potential risks and costs involved, parties organize their activities to enhance predictability and reduce the likelihood of detection and punishment (Lambsdorff 2002; Jancsics 2024b).

Family corruption occurs when the social organization of family and corruption overlap. In this case, individuals who are involved in the organized process of corruption are also members of the organized process of a family. Of course, this is just a partial overlap, so non-family members can also be involved in the same corrupt transaction, while not all family members participate in it. Based on the members' positions in the corrupt transaction, the actors' motivations, and the coordination

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mechanisms, we can differentiate between five types of family corruption. Table 1 shows the types and the main dimensions, along with how they can be understood. Each family corruption configuration presented relies on a distinctive social arrangement and thus can be explained by theories borrowed from different social science disciplines. In this article, I draw on theories from sociology, anthropology, political science, economics, organization studies, and public administration to conceptualize each type and its constituent elements.

I refer to the first type as *family for corruption,* where pre-existing family ties are leveraged to obtain illicit financial benefits, as family provides a trust-based social infrastructure that can facilitate corruption with reduced risk on the agent side. While in this case, family serves the corrupt members' self-interest, the second type, *corruption for family*, has an essential but often latent function in contributing to social cohesion within the family. Here, the family provides sites for many informal activities and gift-type exchanges on a regular basis, with the primary function of further integrating members and subgroups. However, some of these exchanges cross the line into corruption when formal organizational resources, not just private ones, are involved in such exchanges. Here we can find family members on both the agent and the client sides of the transaction. The third type, *corruption for survival through family,* is embedded in macro-level informal institutions, serving as a survival or coping mechanism within a defective formal system. Here, family norms facilitate society-wide informal norms, and family members can be found on both the agent and client sides of the transaction. In the case of *corruption for the family firm,* relatives are members of the same family-owned company that is on the client side of a corrupt transaction. Here, the formal organization is the primary beneficiary of a corrupt transaction, yet the family also benefits from the firm's success. Finally, in the case of *dynastic state capture,* a family becomes so powerful that it can control political institutions, manipulate the law-making process, and channel vast amounts of resources to companies owned by members or quasi-members of the same family.

4 | Family for Corruption

David Cruz, a U.S. Border Patrol agent, became involved in corruption to fund a costly legal battle to help his wife reclaim her son from Mexico (Cobler 2016). As Cruz reflected, "A person who does something like what I did must have the perfect storm in their life at the time they decide to do it." Together with his wife, Susana Lopez-Portillo de Cruz, he devised a smuggling scheme assisting undocumented immigrants through U.S. border checkpoints. His wife acted as a liaison and coordinator in the scheme. She maintained contact with the smuggler who organized the transport of undocumented immigrants and relayed key logistical details—such as bus numbers, locations, and schedules—to her husband. Beyond offering a safety buffer between the agent and the client, her involvement also reduces the risk of betrayal, as their shared family and emotional bond builds a foundation for trust. Even after securing funds for the custody case, the couple continued, enticed by easy profit. They opened a restaurant, the *Burger Patrol*, while under federal surveillance. In 2007, investigators recorded Cruz neglecting ID checks on three occasions. Arrested in 2008 at age 32, he pleaded guilty to transporting and harboring illegal aliens for financial gain. Both spouses received prison sentences exceeding 4 years and later divorced.

As this example suggests, actors in a *family for corruption* cases are typically financially motivated, leveraging familial ties to minimize the transaction costs, the risks, and uncertainty associated with a corrupt deal. In such arrangements, family members often act as intermediaries, helping to obscure the identity of a family member agent, negotiate terms, or enforce deals in informal yet reliable ways. Both transaction cost economics and economic sociology suggest that the family provides an effective informal governance framework, particularly when formal mechanisms like legally enforceable contracts are unavailable or inapplicable.

Rational actors involved in any transaction are often opportunistic—they may betray or exploit their partners if doing so yields greater personal benefits (Husted 1994). To guard against such behavior, legitimate business arrangements usually rely on contracts, clear legal terms, and external enforcement. These protections incur costs, such as searching for partners, drafting agreements, monitoring compliance, and seeking legal recourse when agreements are broken (Lambsdorff et al. 2005).

In corrupt transactions, however, these formal mechanisms are not an option. This means transaction costs are even higher, because actors must invest significant time and resources into verifying trust, ensuring secrecy, monitoring behavior, and enforcing unwritten agreements. Moreover, corrupt actors are

TABLE 1 | Types and dimensions of family corruption.

Family corruption type	Family members' position(s)	Actors' motivation	Coordination mechanisms	Level(s) at which to study the phenomenon
Family for corruption	Agent side	Material gain	Price	Micro
Corruption for family	Agent & client sides	Social cohesion	Family norms	Micro
Corruption for survival through family	Agent & client sides	Survive in dysfunctional formal institutions	Universal & family norms	Micro & macro
Corruption for the family firm	Client side	Material gain for the family firm	Power & organizational culture	Mezzo
Dynastic state capture	In political & economic macro-structures	Dynasty-building	Hierarchy & neopatrimonialism	Macro

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highly vulnerable to betrayal, since both sides know they are engaging in illegal activity and cannot resort to courts or police for protection (Lambsdorff and Teksoz 2005). In this context, family offers a unique solution. The close, long-term, and emotionally grounded nature of familial relationships provides a built-in structure of trust, loyalty, and mutual dependence. These features serve as informal enforcement mechanisms, reducing uncertainty and risk.

Actors in such arrangements are primarily financially motivated, using family ties not out of emotional obligation but as a calculated strategy to reduce transaction costs and maximize gain. As Ledeneva (2018) points out, there is an ambiguity in such cases: while these relationships are deeply social and rooted in kinship, they are simultaneously used as tools for instrumental, interest-based purposes. In family for corruption cases, kinship ties may be emotionally significant, but their function in these arrangements is primarily utilitarian.

In summary, the "family for corruption" model demonstrates how rational actors utilize intimate relationships to establish secure and low-risk environments for corruption. In doing so, sociable, emotionally charged bonds become a proxy for coordination and risk management. Other close-knit social groups, like friendship networks, may also serve similar functions in corruption; however, since the social distance among family members is the shortest, family is best suited for this role.

5 | Corruption for Family

Mailis Reps, former Minister of Education and Research in Estonia, was convicted of serious misconduct for misusing public funds to support private and family activities. In September 2024, the Harju County Court found her guilty of embezzlement and fraud (Turovski 2021; Whyte 2021). According to the court, Reps exploited her ministerial position and resources for personal benefit. She arranged a private birthday celebration at the ministry's premises and hosted a second birthday event at the upscale Tallinn restaurant Mon Repos, using the ministry's budget. Over an extended period, she also used a ministry vehicle to transport her children to and from school, as well as on a family holiday to Croatia. In addition, plane tickets for her children were purchased using ministry funds, and ministry employees were assigned to provide childcare and chauffeur services.

Corruption for family refers to the misuse of formal positions and organizational resources not for personal financial gain but to benefit relatives, driven primarily by kinship obligations and familial norms. Unlike *family for corruption* that is economically motivated, this form serves social functions such as reinforcing family intimacy, reputation, and moral obligations. Corruption for family is a socially integrative practice.

The general theoretical foundation I use here to explain this family corruption type goes back to the classic functionalist argument in sociology and anthropology based on the notion of social equilibrium, which refers to a state of balance in society where all parts function together harmoniously (Turner and Maryanski 1979, 5). This condition is characterized by a high degree of "social integration" or "social cohesion" between members of social groups. Many 20th-century scholars employed this perspective, analyzing how reciprocal gift exchanges (Malinowski 1922; Mauss 1925), ceremonial practices (Radcliffe-Brown 1922), and dance rituals extend beyond their intended and recognized "manifest" goals to serve "latent" functions, fostering social bonds and restoring and maintaining social harmony and cohesion (Merton 1968). Applying a similar logic to the context of corruption for family, we can say that individual family members may benefit from certain transactions; however, a key element here is the corrupt association's impact on the very essence of the family's social fabric. While these acts might break legal norms, they—often implicitly—reinforce family solidarity, prestige, and internal cohesion—akin to the way traditional rituals function in tribal societies.

Family norms are important coordinating mechanisms, as they create obligations that pressure a corrupt agent to take actions that benefit one or more relatives. At the same time, these actions can also cement their position in the family. In these "clashing moral values" situations, there is a conflict between particularistic values and norms governing the behavior of family members and more universal values related to one's official role (de Graaf 2007). Nepotistic hiring practices across Nigeria, India, the United States, and Mexico are common, driven by obligations to kin members (Lomnitz 1997; Smith 2007; Gupta 1995). Corruption for family, therefore, functions as a form of social glue. There are constant resource exchanges between family members aimed at enhancing cohesion, and some of these exchanges are corrupt, utilizing organizational resources instead of private ones. However, the difference between legal and corrupt is often not even recognized, or the actions are actually perceived as morally justified by the actors involved. Examples include taking a company car filled with gas to enjoy a family vacation without the employer's knowledge, having company staff run personal errands for family members (like picking up kids or cleaning personal vehicles), assigning employees to conduct home renovations or repairs, taking office supplies (such as paper, ink, laptops, etc.) for children's school projects, and using a company credit card for family expenses.

Nepotism, which is probably the most well-known form of *corruption for family*, indicates kinship preference over merit; it is a widespread practice across sectors and countries (Schilpzand et al. 2024). It often occurs when individuals in power use their discretion to benefit relatives in hiring, promotion, or compensation. Studies show high global prevalence, with surveys revealing that personal connections play a significant role in public sector employment, especially in developing countries (Meyer-Sahling et al. 2018; Riaño 2021; Fafchamps and Labonne 2017). Notable examples include judicial nepotism in Mexico (Ríos-Figueroa 2018; Brassiolo et al. 2021) and in the U.S. (Berens and Shiffman 2020), as well as sports-related cases where unqualified family members were chosen as coaches or competitive athletes (Kahler 2022; Close and Yeung 2023).

Since these transactions are usually based on reciprocity, the agent can expect something in return from the family. While in

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the family for corruption cases, the participants benefit financially, when agents commit corruption for their family, the counter-transfer is often not material (Larsen and Watson 2001). It may take different forms of labor—for example, cooking for a parent or caring for children (Carrier 1991; Graycar and Jancsics 2017; Murcott 1983). Moreover, the counter-gifts for serving the family through corruption do not always come from the original giftee or even any particular relative but from the entire family, manifesting as symbolic capital such as recognition, honor, prestige, or elevation in status within the kinship network (Bourdieu 1997).

6 | Corruption for Survival Through Family

In many post-socialist societies, government services such as healthcare remained of extremely low quality or even inaccessible to many people, keeping family networks crucial for supplementing such public functions. Being just "another anonymous patient," without personal connections to doctors or nurses, almost always guaranteed long wait lists and low-quality service in the extremely underfunded health care system (Rivkin-Fish 2005). Qualitative research in the post-Soviet Ukrainian health care sector in 2009 revealed widespread family-based activities to access services through unofficial channels (Williams and Onoshchenko 2015). Here is an interview quotation from the study:

> If you personally know the chief physician, you will get absolutely different treatment. I always go to the doctors pulling strings. Once I recommended a good doctor to my sister but without introducing her to him. She visited this doctor without being patronized first and did not receive proper quality and care from him as I did.

The example above illustrates that family-based corruption can also function as a tool for survival in societies where formal institutions are weak, inefficient, or dysfunctional. Corruption often becomes a morally justified and socially embedded strategy when access to basic goods and services is constrained by scarcity or bureaucratic rigidity. Informal institutions—unwritten, socially shared norms—emerge as adaptive mechanisms and are often embedded within kinship networks, making the family a key conduit for navigating systemic obstacles. These informal norms play a significant role in societies with low levels of trust in government and business, where the intersection between formal pressures and informal practices gives rise to them. Although shaped by historical and cultural factors, informal institutions are typically responses to the rigidity or inadequacy of the political or economic subsystems (Ledeneva 2008). In such environments, people often rely on family ties to circumvent inflexible systems or gain access to essential resources, including jobs, housing, education, and healthcare. Historically in Communist and post-communist societies, the scarcity economy forced individuals to use their connections to secure basic needs, creating deeply embedded informal institutions. In most societies, informal institutions and family networks are deeply intertwined, as families, the primary socialization units, serve as an intermediary social form that transmits and reinforces societal norms (Karhunen et al. 2018).

When introducing corruption into the exchange between family and informal networks, we arrive at a new convergence of three distinct social arrangements. In this scenario, following the rules of an informal institution, individuals utilize family networks to acquire resources through corrupt means. This type of corruption is at least partially coordinated by an external societal normative system that disseminates through kinship units. In essence, the family serves as a conduit for the functioning of a macro-level collective understanding.

These informal institutions—such as *blat* in Russia and *guanxi* in China—are culturally specific yet functionally similar: They provide a way to "beat the system." (Karhunen et al. 2018; Lovell 2005; Makovicky and Henig 2018; Bian 2006; Schramm and Taube 2005) Though not inherently corrupt, they often enable corruption when used to access public resources. For example, *blat* relationships allowed Soviet families to obtain goods, influence military assignments, or secure better housing through personal connections. Even after communism, these practices persist as "economies of favor." Similarly, *guanxi* operates as a vast network of reciprocal relationships in China, often beginning within the family and extending to business and political life.

Corruption for survival through family is a response to systemic failure. It connects macro-level breakdowns with micro-level family practices, revealing how family networks serve not just emotional or social purposes but also as practical infrastructures for navigating and coping with broken systems. In doing so, they normalize and reproduce corruption as part of everyday life, making it justifiable as a survival tactic in dysfunctional political and economic institutions.

7 | Corruption for the Family Firm

In early 2025, federal prosecutors in California charged David Sanson, chief executive of the Concord-based development firm DeNova Homes, and his son Trent Sanson, the company's vice president, with conspiracy and bribery (U.S. Attorney's Office Northern District of California 2025). According to the indictment, the two allegedly sought to secure favorable treatment from a city council member in exchange for financial inducements linked to one of their residential projects. DeNova Homes has been a prominent developer in the East Bay region, including the Aviano project—a multi-phase, 533-unit residential development in Antioch. Federal authorities reported that the firm had encountered regulatory obstacles when the city's Engineering and Development Services Division determined that required public infrastructure improvements had not been completed, resulting in the withholding of bond approvals. To address these challenges, prosecutors allege that Trent Sanson initiated private communications with a city council member to seek assistance in resolving issues related to the project's pending approvals.

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This case highlights family corruption manifested within family firms, which blend formal business structures with informal kinship dynamics. Family firms are commonly associated with nepotism and bifurcation bias—the unequal treatment of family and non-family employees (Madison et al. 2018). In fact, in a family firm, nepotism is considered a legitimate practice. Interestingly, nepotism in family firms often reduces corruption types derived from the aforementioned principal-agent dilemma by aligning the principal and the agent, who in this case are both family members. Kin relations minimize room for self-serving behavior by agents that is hidden from the principal. Yet, these firms are particularly vulnerable to corruption aimed at benefiting the firm itself, due to centralized organizational authority, emotional loyalty, and informal cultural norms.

Historically, the family firm was the most essential form of business organization in Europe, as most trading houses in the Middle Ages had a familial character (Fleischer 2023). They are still the dominant business model, representing over two-thirds of enterprises worldwide (European Commission 2008; Song et al. 2021). Family firms often combine formal rules with informal family norms, leading to hybrid structures. Their self-identity includes non-financial goals like protecting family reputation and maintaining emotional bonds, collectively known as socioemotional wealth (Gomez-Mejia et al. 2007). This can lead to ethical decision-making to uphold the family's name and social standing but also opens the door to corruption when family interests are prioritized over legal or professional norms.

A relevant concept for understanding corruption for the family firm is borrowed from management science and the corporate crime literature, namely the idea of the *corrupt organization*, where an entire formal private entity is both the client and the primary beneficiary of a corrupt transaction (Jancsics 2019; Pinto et al. 2008). Such corruption is motivated by the pursuit of an organizational advantage rather than individual gain. A typical example of corrupt organization is when private companies provide kickbacks to public officials in return for government contracts.

The two main coordination mechanisms in the case of a corrupt organization mentioned in the literature are centralized power and a "toxic" culture, both of which are readily available in family firms (Jancsics 2019). Family members often have unchecked power and may suppress internal controls like audits or whistleblower systems. In family enterprises owners and executives have significantly higher decision-making discretion than in non-family businesses, so their ability to informally authorize corrupt acts and demand loyalty from subordinates creates an especially high corruption risk (Le Breton-Miller and Miller 2024). Furthermore, in paternalistic family firms the founders' norms and values are often perpetuated due to their strong status or even a cult of personality, thereby fostering a culture of corruption. Family-member employees may abandon universal or official ethical norms for particularistic values that benefit their family (Aubert 1952; LeVine and Campbell 1972; Ryan and Bogart 1997).

The corrupt organizational phenomenon often emerges as a response to highly competitive business environments (Castro et al. 2020). Ultimately, family firms contest the notion of impersonal, rule-driven corporations; however, such a high level of informality increases their susceptibility to organization-related corruption compared to other firms. Their structure enables this unique form of corruption where familial loyalty, concentrated power, and informal norms facilitate collective wrongdoing for both the company and the family.

8 | Dynastic State Capture

The presidency of Zine al-Abidine Ben Ali in Tunisia, from 1987 until his removal during the 2011 Tunisian Revolution, was marked by authoritarian rule and corruption, as well as the substantial enrichment and empowerment of his family and relatives. Notably, his second wife, Leïla Trabelsi, and her extended family became notorious for amassing wealth and exerting influence. The members of the so-called "Trabelsi clan" acquired control over the most profitable sectors of the Tunisian economy, leveraging state-granted monopolies and securing favorable contracts through political connections. They frequently expropriated private businesses under questionable pretenses. Although less publicly scrutinized than the Trabelsi family, Ben Ali's close relatives also benefited from his regime's power. At the peak of his rule, at least 662 firms were identified as owned by the Ben Ali family, all of which were confiscated following the Jasmine Revolution (Rijkers et al. 2017). The state played a significant role in supporting these enterprises by implementing strict regulations that limited investment, thereby suppressing competition and benefitting certain actors within key sectors such as telecommunications, real estate, construction, and air transport. Consequently, approximately 88% of the net profits of firms associated with Ben Ali derived from these industries.

The regime of Zine al-Abidine Ben Ali is widely considered a textbook case of *dynastic state capture*, particularly in its later years. This is a form of grand corruption where a ruling family gains systemic control over state institutions, converting political authority into private, intergenerational wealth. Unlike corporate or party-based state capture (Innes 2014; Dávid-Barrett 2023Dávid-Barrett 2023), dynastic state capture blends formal legal structures with informal patrimonial logic, creating a facade of modern bureaucracy while functioning as a patrimonial system (Jancsics 2024b). Along with Tunisia's Ben Ali regime, Hungary under Viktor Orbán is another prime example of dynastic state capture. Orbán's family rose from modest origins to immense wealth through a network of privatizations, political connections, and state-linked contracts beginning in the 1990s (Pethő et al. 2025). His father and brothers built a lucrative mining and construction empire that thrived on EU-funded public projects, while his wife and in-laws accumulated extensive real estate and business holdings intertwined with powerful oligarchs. Orbán's son-in-law, István Tiborcz, and his close ally and childhood friend Lőrinc Mészáros, who could be regarded as pseudo-family, epitomize the family's broader system of dynastic enrichment built around state power.

Dynastic capture involves redistributive corruption—where state institutions become tools to channel resources to family

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members (Jancsics 2019). The driving force behind this well-designed and sophisticated process is the control exerted over the government's central authority responsible for collecting and redistributing resources. In captured states, laws and regulations are tailored to serve particularistic interests, so formal bureaucratic rules are followed, but in reality, they informally redistribute power and wealth within a ruling family.

The historical shift from patrimonialism to bureaucracy, first described by Weber (1922), was the most significant organizational transformation shaping the transition from medieval to industrial societies. Patrimonialism was the dominant form of social organization, based on private households and alliances among them. It even manifested as a macro-level phenomenon, where the ruler legally owned the state and treated it as personal property, with no clear distinction between public resources and family wealth. In Weber's framework, modern bureaucratic organizations stand in stark contrast to every characteristic of patrimonialism. Loyalty, a key element of patrimonial relationships, was replaced by impersonal adherence to the abstract duties and goals as well as one's position within the hierarchy. In a bureaucracy employees are remunerated by salaries fixed by law, as opposed to patrimonial, informal exchanges of resources such as favors and gifts. The era of modern rational-legal bureaucracies physically separated the workplace from the household by establishing specialized buildings—offices, factories, stores, barracks, prisons—where individuals in formal roles were set apart from their families.

Although patrimonialism appeared to decline with the emergence of sovereign nation-states and capitalism, by the late 20th century, a surprising resurgence was noted in various regions, including the Middle East, former socialist countries in Central and Eastern Europe, post-colonial Africa, Latin America, and even the United States (Lachmann 2011). In modern contexts this has evolved into neopatrimonialism, where traditional informal norms coexist with formal institutions (Ermakoff 2011). In contemporary governments, neopatrimonialism is often associated with personal loyalty, informal networks, and cliques that lack direct familial connections (Charrad and Adams 2011). Therefore, I suggest introducing the term "dynastic state capture" to specifically highlight the family element and dynasty-building efforts in this grand corruption form.

State capture is the most sophisticated form of corruption, characterized by a central authority that collects and reallocates resources to benefit specific groups by manipulating laws and policies. In dynastic state capture, a whole family controls the government, manipulates legal structures, and hides its influence behind formal bureaucratic structures while informally operating as a neopatrimonial system.

9 | Discussion

This article has proposed a new conceptual framework for analyzing corrupt transactions in which family membership is relevant, highlighting how familial structures intersect with corrupt practices across various contexts. I emphasize that both *family* and *corruption* function as forms of social organizations, as they are designed to maintain predictability and pursue collective goals. When these forms overlap, like a Venn diagram, in their intersection, distinct types of corruption emerge, collectively referred to as family corruption. Family corruption does not occur randomly; it exists because it offers specific and tangible benefits to those involved.

The study introduces a fivefold typology: (1) *family for corruption*, where kin ties are used to reduce the transaction costs of corrupt acts; (2) *corruption for family*, where corruption reinforces familial bonds; (3) *corruption for survival through family*, occurring under institutional dysfunction; (4) *corruption for the family firm*, where business interests are intertwined with familial advantage; and (5) *dynastic state capture*, where ruling families institutionalize power and wealth accumulation.

These family corruption types are also more effectively studied at a particular level of analysis due to their nature and their embeddedness in social life. Family for corruption and corruption for family are micro-level phenomena involving members of a particular family and their corrupt "business" partners. Corruption for survival through family is also a family-level occurrence, but to fully understand it we also need to study the macro-level informal institutions facilitated by the family unit. Corruption for the family firm is a mezzo-level phenomenon, where the internal dynamics of a family-owned company are the most relevant factors for analysis. In dynastic state capture, families infiltrate the highest levels of government bureaucracies and private companies within a country, making it a phenomenon best analyzed from a macro-level perspective.

Each type draws from diverse theoretical traditions such as transaction cost theory, functionalism, informality, corporate crime, and patrimonialism. The framework is meant to be illustrative, not exhaustive, and serves as a foundation for future empirical research and policy development. Ultimately, the article argues that family is not merely incidental to corruption—it is often a core mechanism that sustains and legitimizes corruption within broader social systems.

9.1 | Some Policy Implications of Family Corruption

Many anti-corruption reforms fail because they implement one-size-fits-all solutions without considering the specific nature of corruption in each situation (Jancsics 2019; Johnston 2005; Torsello and Venard 2016). This is particularly true in cases of family corruption, where kinship loyalties, social norms, and institutional contexts are essential. The key policy insight is not about adding generic regulations but about matching the tools to the specific type of family corruption and combining legal measures with social strategies. Given the limited space, here I highlight only a few potential policy implications of family corruption.

Kinship ties often function as low-cost trust networks that facilitate illicit transactions, but in "family for corruption," they play a more instrumental role for interest-based purposes, so self-interest can ultimately override family loyalty.

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In such cases, asymmetric punishment—penalizing only one actor—can undermine trust and incentivize whistleblowing (Lambsdorff and Nell 2007; Rose-Ackerman 1999; Abbink et al. 2014). Anti-nepotism laws and merit-based recruitment systems aim to curb "corruption for family", but these top-down measures often fail against this deeply social form of corruption when informal norms of loyalty persist. Similarly, "corruption for survival" rooted in kinship safety nets requires macro-level solutions—reforming dysfunctional state or market institutions—rather than punitive enforcement that might harm vulnerable groups. In family firms, external oversight is crucial. Tools include mandatory disclosure of related-party transactions, audits for firms with public contracts, and transparency on beneficial ownership to expose hidden family interests (Jancsics 2018a). In contexts of "dynastic state capture", preventive efforts must strengthen checks and balances before capture occurs—through term limits, independent judiciaries, and autonomous oversight bodies. Once capture is entrenched, domestic remedies are limited, and international mechanisms become vital. For instance, the EU has frozen billions in funds to Hungary over systemic corruption and the misuse of public resources by politically connected elites.

9.2 | Family Corruption in Different Cultural Contexts

Finally, it is essential to discuss this framework's relevance across cultural contexts. Although the family corruption types presented in this article reflect general patterns across cultures, important nuances offer deeper insight into the phenomenon. For example, both blat and guanxi networks often serve as a survival mechanism in dysfunctional institutional contexts, creating a trustworthy infrastructure for corruption, frequently rooted in extended kinship ties. Thus, they both fit the "corruption for survival through the family" pattern. Yet, they also differ in cultural and historical roots (Ledeneva 2008). Guanxi originates in Confucian family ethics that extend principles of respect and harmony to wider social relations, allowing non-kin to become part of one's network as pseudo-kin through reciprocal exchanges (Bian 2006; Gao et al. 2012; He 2011). In contrast, blat emerged from Soviet-era distrust, functioning as a closed system limited to close personal ties (Ayios 2004, 14; Karhunen et al. 2018). Consequently, guanxi can develop into large brokered networks with more explicit norms, while blat remains smaller, more insular, and governed by less-defined rules.

Furthermore, future empirical research on family corruption should systematically examine how macro- and micro-level social norms interact, going beyond the already identified cases of "corruption for survival through the family." In certain cultures, such as those in Nigeria, Senegal, and India, family members are expected to show unconditional support for relatives (Gupta 1995; Smith 2007; Blundo and de Sardan 2006). However, in other cultures, those core family duties—such as providing financial help, even if through corrupt means—are less emphasized. This indicates that national or ethnic-level cultural influences can shape family norms and create contexts in which corruption is more or less supported.

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